

FOSS in India: Perspectives of an American Anthropologist



In her doctoral thesis done at the University of Manchester, UK, titled 'Free and Open Source Software (FOSS) in India: Mobilising Technology for the National Good', American anthropologist Dr Jasmine Folz addresses the question "What can the case of FOSS in India tell us about the roles and relationships between technology, autonomy, and the state?" This article gives a quick summary of some topics discussed in the thesis to convey a flavour of the work.

Dr Folz spent one year in India doing field work for her thesis, travelling and interacting extensively with many different players in the Indian FOSS space. Studies of FOSS in India have been very few and mostly lacking in depth, and even those that have been done are confined to its technological and economic aspects. This work is therefore unique and valuable in many ways as it provides the deeper insights and understanding that only anthropologists are capable of, and Dr Folz has maintained the rigour and focus of her profession in this effort. Among other things, it could help answer frequently asked questions like "Why is there very little contribution from India to the global FOSS corpus?" Much of this review quotes directly from the thesis itself.

Historical origins of FOSS in India

Modern science and technology (S&T) came to India bundled with the European colonial project, and it was viewed with suspicion, if not hostility. Searching for alternatives to modern S&T (especially in the areas of healthcare, agriculture, village industries, etc) was thus a part of the freedom struggle, and it continued well beyond Independence. Even decades later, large corporations like IBM and Coca Cola came to be seen as symbols of continued western domination. When software and IT became a major force in the country from the 1980s onwards, driven by the global outsourcing industry, Microsoft too joined the list of such corporations.

The Indian FOSS community took root in this context, with a strong nationalist position and in favour of the

digitally disadvantaged sections of the population. In fact, FOSS can be considered a descendant of Gandhian Swadeshi, which includes self-rule via home grown craft and technology, though many in the FOSS community may be opposed to Gandhi on other issues. The Indian FOSS community has always been in conversation with larger issues of what role technology can or should play in Indian society; FOSS came to be seen as a way to develop the nation along particular moral and material pathways, and for that material development to be understood in moral terms.

While sections of the Indian government were sympathetic to FOSS, the former stayed rather 'non-aligned' between proprietary and free software, given how the former was the backbone of the country's